

26 READING BOOKS



A book is a garden you can carry in your pocket.

Arabian proverb

A book gives knowledge, but it is life that gives understanding.

Hebrew proverb

□ VOCABULARY INPUT

Dealing with this topic you will come across the following vocabulary. Read it and look up the unknown words in your dictionary.

- **main literary genres:**

- I. POETRY: a) *epic poetry* (long narrative poetry with a plot)
b) *lyric poetry* (short poems that reflect personal feelings)
c) *verse drama* (drama written in verse)

- II. PROSE: a) *fiction*
b) *non-fiction*

- III. DRAMA: a) *tragedy* (a play with a sad ending)
b) *comedy* (a play with a happy ending): comedy of manners, romantic comedy, parody, satire, tragicomedy

- **other literary genres:** ballad, chivalric romance, fable, fairy tale, fantasy, grotesque, heroic epic, legend, novel, ode, travel book

- **reasons for reading:** to enrich our lives, to learn about cultural heritage, to develop our imagination, to improve our vocabulary, to escape from the real world, to please our senses

- **authors:** poet, novelist, writer, dramatist, playwright, satirist, autobiographer, critic, pseudonym

- **book analysis:** author, protagonist, character, plot, conflict, setting, message of the book
– *features:* allegorical, ironic, satirical, humorous, religious, mythological, narrative, fictional, historical, legendary

- **bookshops:** originals, translations, simplified versions, bestsellers

- **in the library:** to lend/to borrow, lending period, to extend, overdue, unique books, current and older issues, study room, silence is requested, lending card, reminder card

- **crisis in reading:** high prices of books, lack of time, poor choice in libraries, preference of e-books, film versions vs. books, illegal photocopying, downloading

- **Nobel Prize winners:** award, ceremony, honour

□ DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Before reading the text, discuss the following questions in class.

1. Did you read a lot as a child? Do you remember your first book?
2. What kind of books do young Slovaks read?
3. Are comic books popular among Slovak readers? Why/why not?

4. Where can you buy/borrow books?
5. If you like reading, do you read in the original language or in translation?
6. Which book are you going to read in the near future?
7. Have you ever read an e-book? What was it like?
8. What do you know about winners of the Nobel Prize for literature?
9. Have you ever read a book written by an English or American writer? If yes, say which writer(s) and what you have read by them.
10. Why do some people prefer going to the cinema to watch a filmed version of a book instead of reading the book?

□ TEXT

Read the texts below in silence. Check the meaning of the words in bold and answer the questions below.

CHILDREN'S BOOKS

Our first books are usually read to us by our parents or grandparents. These are **fairy tales** or stories and they normally have more pictures than text. They take children to the world of fantasy and teach them to **distinguish good from evil**. Children's books by *Hans Christian Andersen* and the *Brothers Grimm* are popular worldwide. Classic English children's books like *Alice in Wonderland* (written by *Lewis Carroll*) and *Winnie the Pooh* (written by *A. A. Milne*) are read and loved by many generations of English children.

1. What kind of books are usually read to small children?
2. According to the text, who are the most famous English authors of children's literature? Have you read anything by them?

READING FICTION VS. NON-FICTION

Nowadays, people in Slovakia can read both original Slovak books and books **translated from** different languages, **mainly** English. They read books from both **fiction** and **non-fiction genres**. Boys usually read **adventure stories** or science fiction, girls prefer **romances** or **novels**. Many young Slovaks have started to read in English. There exist a lot of English books that are **simplified** and are not difficult to read for non-native speakers of English. Adults like to read detective stories, historical novels or **travel books**. Some also read non-fiction genres, such as **biographies** or **scientific papers**. There are people who enjoy reading **poetry**. There are not many of them because this genre is not easy to read. **Speculative** fiction for adults and **fantasy series** for children have become very popular genres **in recent years**. People also enjoy watching **film versions** of famous books which they have read. In Western Europe, people like to read **comic books** – there are more pictures than text and the story is usually **adventurous** and dynamic.

3. According to the text, which literary genres are popular among boys, girls and adults?
4. What are comic books? Find the explanation in the text above.

BOOKSHOPS AND LIBRARIES

Books can be bought in a **wide range of** bookshops. Some are small and quite **specialised**; others are situated in big shopping centres. People can drink a cup of tea or coffee there and sometimes see a presentation of a new book. Bestsellers can also be bought in **news-stands** or supermarkets. It is becoming more and more popular to buy a book **via the Internet** in an Internet bookshop. It is also possible to read a book **in electronic form**; such a book is called an **e-book**. In England and other countries of Western Europe **publishing companies publish** many more books than in Slovakia. People buy them in mega stores or small specialised bookshops (e. g. children's bookshops).

The place where books are **lent** and **borrowed** for a **fee** is called a library. A good one is usually **equipped with** a wider range of books which are lent to library members for an agreed **lending period**. If it is **overdue**, the lending can be **extended** for some time. Unique books, **current** and older issues of magazines and newspapers are available just for reading in study rooms where silence is **requested**. Nowadays, almost every educational institution and public library **provide** an on-line service which helps readers check all information about the books they request.

5. Where and how can books be bought according to the text?
6. What services do libraries provide to their members?

READING CRISIS

In general, people in our country do not buy many books. There are several reasons why there is a **crisis** of reading nowadays. The first one is that books are getting more and more expensive and people cannot **afford** to buy many of them. This also **leads to illegal photocopying**, mainly **among** students who often copy textbooks. The second reason is that people do not read so much anymore. People do not look for information in books (such as encyclopedias or textbooks) as much as they used to in the past. They need to save as much time as possible. Therefore, they prefer to **look up the information on the Internet**. Instead of reading good fiction, they watch films. Reading a book takes days or weeks, watching a film just one or two hours. People do not need to concentrate so much; they do not need to imagine things. Everything is ready for them on the screen. Moreover, teenagers prefer the interactive virtual reality of computer games. They **participate in** the game, **take action**, feel what the heroes feel. Adults read more and more magazines because **it takes less time** and concentration than reading a book.

7. What are the main reasons for the reading crisis mentioned in the text above?
8. What are the main consequences of the reading crisis mentioned in the text above?

WHAT IS THE FUTURE OF BOOKS?

To change this negative trend it is very important to develop a good relationship with reading and literature from a very young age. When a positive relationship is developed, books **enrich** our lives. We read **for pleasure**, we train our imagination. Books make us think, **amuse** us and give us answers to some questions. A good book is also a pleasant way **to escape** from the real world. When we read a lot, we improve our vocabulary too. People who read more, **express themselves** better.

Some people think that books will **die out** one day. They say that everything will be read in electronic form and people will have less and less time to read books. Others **argue** that reading is a hobby for many people and books are a part of the cultural **heritage** of every nation. That is why they think that the book will never **cease** to exist and is **irreplaceable**.

9. How does reading enrich and shape our personalities?
10. Comment on the opinions on the future of books mentioned in the text above.

NOBEL PRIZE FOR LITERATURE

Every year, the *Swedish Academy* **announces** the *Nobel Prize winners* for literature. It is based on the last will of Alfred Nobel. Winning the *Nobel Prize* for literature is one of the highest **honours** for a writer. Books by such authors become **widely** translated and sold. The authors get the award from *His Majesty the King of Sweden* during a *Nobel Prize Award Ceremony* in Stockholm. They **are awarded** it for their **overall contribution** to literature or their **uniqueness**. Here are some of the Nobel Prize winners for literature: *Tomas Tranströmer* (2011), *Mario Vargas Llosa* (2010), *Harold Pinter* (2005), *Elfriede Jelinek* (2004), *Seamus Heaney* (1995), *Pablo Neruda* (1971), *Samuel Beckett* (1969), *John Steinbeck* (1962), *Ernest Hemingway* (1954). Literature is the most available piece of art, enjoyed by literature lovers and readers of all ages.

11. What is the Nobel Prize in literature awarded for?
12. Name three Nobel Prize winners for literature.

□ VOCABULARY LIST

adventure story [əd'ventʃə(r)] – dobrodružný príbeh
adventurous [əd'ventʃərəs] – dobrodružný
to afford – dovoliť si
among – medzi (viac než dvoma)
to amuse [ə'mju:z] – pobaviť, rozveseliť
to announce – vyhlásiť
to argue – argumentovať, tvrdiť
to award [ə'wɔ:d] – udeliť cenu
award ceremony – slávnosť odovzdávania ceny
biography [baɪ'ɒɡrəfi] – životopis
to borrow – požičať si
to cease [si:s] – zastaviť, prestať
comic book – komiks
crisis – kríza
current [kʌrənt] – súčasný
to die out – vymrieť
e-book – internetová kniha (v elektronickej forme)
to enrich – obohatiť
to equip with – vybaviť, zariadiť
to escape – uniknúť
to express oneself – vyjadrovať sa
to extend – rozšíriť
fairy tale – rozprávka
fantasy series – séria kníh žánru fantasy
fee [fi:] – poplatok
fiction [fɪkʃn] – beletria
film version – filmové spracovanie knihy
heritage [herɪtɪdʒ] – dedičstvo
His Majesty the King [mædʒəstɪ] – Jeho Kráľovská Výsosť
honour [ɒnər] (AmE: honor) – česť, pocta
genre – žáner
in recent years [ri:snt] – v nedávnych rokoch
irreplaceable [ɪrɪpleɪsəbl] – nenahraditeľný
to lend – požičať
lending period – výpožičná doba

mainly – hlavne
newsstand – novinový stánok
Nobel Prize winner – nositeľ Nobelovej ceny
non-fiction – nebeletristická, literatúra faktu
novel – román
overall contribution – celkový prínos
overdue – oneskorený
to participate in – zúčastniť sa
pleasure [pleʒə(r)] – potešenie, radosť
poetry – poézia
to provide [prə'vaɪd] – poskytnúť
to publish [pʌblɪʃ] – vydať, publikovať
publishing company – vydavateľstvo
to request – vyžadovať, požadovať
romance – ľúbostný román
scientific paper [saɪən'tɪfɪk] – vedecká štúdia
to simplify [sɪmplɪfaɪ] – zjednodušiť
specialised [speʃəlaɪzd] – špecializovaný
speculative – špekulatívny
uniqueness – jedinečnosť
to take action – konať
travel book – cestopis
to translate from – preložiť z
widely – široko

a wide range of – široký výber
to distinguish good from evil [dɪ'stɪŋɡwɪʃ] – rozlíšiť dobro od zla
in electronic form – v elektronickej podobe
to lead to illegal photocopying [li:d] – viesť k nelegálnemu kopírovaniu
to look up the information on the Internet – vyhľadať informáciu(e) na internete
to take less time – zabráť menej času
via the Internet [vaɪə] – prostredníctvom internetu

□ VOCABULARY PRACTICE

Task 1 Which literature genres from the box below would you recommend to somebody who likes reading about...?

Example: deep feelings and dreams written in verse

poems

fairy tales – poems – detective stories – science fiction – novel of manners – fables – absurd dramas – historical novels – comic books – biographies – travel books – allegories – short stories – parodies – grotesques – heroic epics

1. folklore heroes, fairies, princesses and talking animals
2. science and technology and the future of life on Earth
3. detectives who investigate a crime, usually a murder
4. somebody's life
5. experiences and adventures from journeys
6. cartoon characters in a dynamic story

Task 2 What genres are the following books? Who were they written by?

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1. Romeo and Juliet
2. A Farewell to Arms
3. The Da Vinci Code
4. The Catcher in the Rye
5. Hamlet
6. Pygmalion
7. Animal Farm
8. Sense and Sensibility
9. The Raven
10. Waiting for Godot

Task 3 Which books from the list above are the following characters from?



1. a wounded soldier fighting on the Italian front during World War I is sent to a hospital in Milan where he falls in love
2. a Prince of Denmark who wants to avenge the death of his father
3. a sixteen-year-old boy who is describing his experiences in New York
4. a professor, interested in historical symbols, investigating a murder
5. a teenage couple who love each other despite the hate of their families and die together in the end

Task 4 Explain the meaning of the following words in English. Look in a dictionary if necessary.

author – main characters – plot – main conflict – setting

Task 5 What do we call authors of the following genres in English?



Example: essay – essayist

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|------------------------|--------------------------|
| 1. poem – _____ | 4. drama – _____ |
| 2. novel – _____ | 5. satire – _____ |
| 3. short story – _____ | 6. autobiography – _____ |

Task 6 Form adjectives from the following nouns.



Example: hero – heroic

- | | |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|
| 1. adventure – _____ | 8. humour – _____ |
| 2. legend – _____ | 9. myth – _____ |
| 3. history – _____ | 10. religion – _____ |
| 4. fiction – _____ | 11. allegory – _____ |
| 5. narration – _____ | 12. satire – _____ |
| 6. literature – _____ | 13. irony – _____ |
| 7. tragedy – _____ | 14. criticism – _____ |